

'Nonbuildings' for a grand zoo

ARCHITECTURE / ROBERT CAMPBELL

Although it may come as a surprise to some, it looks as if the proposal now being developed for the new Zoo in Franklin Park could turn out to be one of Boston's best buildings.

A year ago, nothing could have seemed less likely. At that time, when the final feasibility study for the new Zoo was released, it was found to be based on a design concept that to many persons looked like a disaster.

The proposal was for a single mammoth structure, the shape of an airplane hangar, more than 300 feet wide and something like a thousand feet long. Completely lacking any spatial variety or interest, the building also seemed to be overscaled and out of character with Franklin Park, part of the famous park system originally created for Boston by Frederick Law Olmstead in the 19th century.

In a further stroke of what many saw as vandalism, the scheme would have casually demolished the pleasant old Victorian refectory building and replaced it with a parking garage.

The proposal drew so much criticism from members of the Sierra Club, the Landmarks Commission, the Boston Society of Landscape Architects and various community groups, that its sponsor in the Boston Zoological Society and Metropolitan District Commission grew slightly paranoid, put the project under wraps, cancelled public hearings after having scheduled them, and, in general, acted as if they had

just been caught bugging the Water-gate.

Predictably, the result was only to increase distrust.

That distrust should dissipate quickly when the current scheme is made public. At the initiative of the architects, Huygens and Tappe, the all-under-one-roof concept has been abandoned and the zoo broken up into several clusters of round, tent-like pavilions, connected to each other by enclosed arcades. There are three of these tent clusters, each housing a different kind of environment — desert, jungle and plain — each with its appropriate topography, vegetation and animals. The arcades that connect the tents, will contain concessions, orientation and educational displays, and services.

Following current trends in zoo display, the animals will not be in cages but instead will roam freely through the natural habitats, with the human visitors watching from raised, bridge-like pathways. In good weather, of course, both animals and visitors can also go outdoors. Although the indoor area amounts to more than six acres, or the equivalent of 10 football fields, nothing about the complex seems likely to overwhelm the park, the animals or the visitors. The whole thing fits loosely and comfortably into the natural land forms and tree patterns of the site.

From a structural point of view, the zoo is equally imaginative. Roofs

will be made of a Teflon fabric thin enough to let most of the sunlight through. These cloth roofs will be hung on cables from huge steel trussed arches that will span some 240 feet. Partly inspired by the world-famous "tent" structures of the German engineer Frei Otto, the zoo's engineers, Weidinger Associates, have come up with some new wrinkles technologically, notably a proposal to maintain a slight vacuum inside the tents to suck down and thus stabilize the fabric roof — making the whole thing a kind of reverse balloon.

Architecturally, the effect will be that of a "nonbuilding" — no doors, walls, windows, ceilings, floors, columns or cages — nothing but space flooded with light through the translucent tent roof.

The design is still evolving and some serious problems remain. No one, for example, has yet got a solution for the parking problem. But it's encouraging that the city traffic department, the BRA and the consultants who did the Boston Transportation Review, are all cooperating and are looking for a solution that will work with city-wide transportation plans.

It's also encouraging that a greater effort is being made, this time groups and organizations to participate in the design review process.

A lot could go wrong between now and Opening Day, 1977, but, with some luck, a truly exciting building may be in the works.